

# MERCHANTS & CAPITAL

“As long as there remain opportunities for business among his own countrymen, there the

Indian merchant will be found.’

—Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi”

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# *Eight* **COMMUNITIES**

**01. Parsis**

**02. Chettiars**

**03. Punjabis**

**04. Sindhis**

**05. Marwaris**

**06. Gujaratis**

**07. Muslim Merchants**

**08. European Christians &**

**Baghdadi Jews**



# The PARSIS



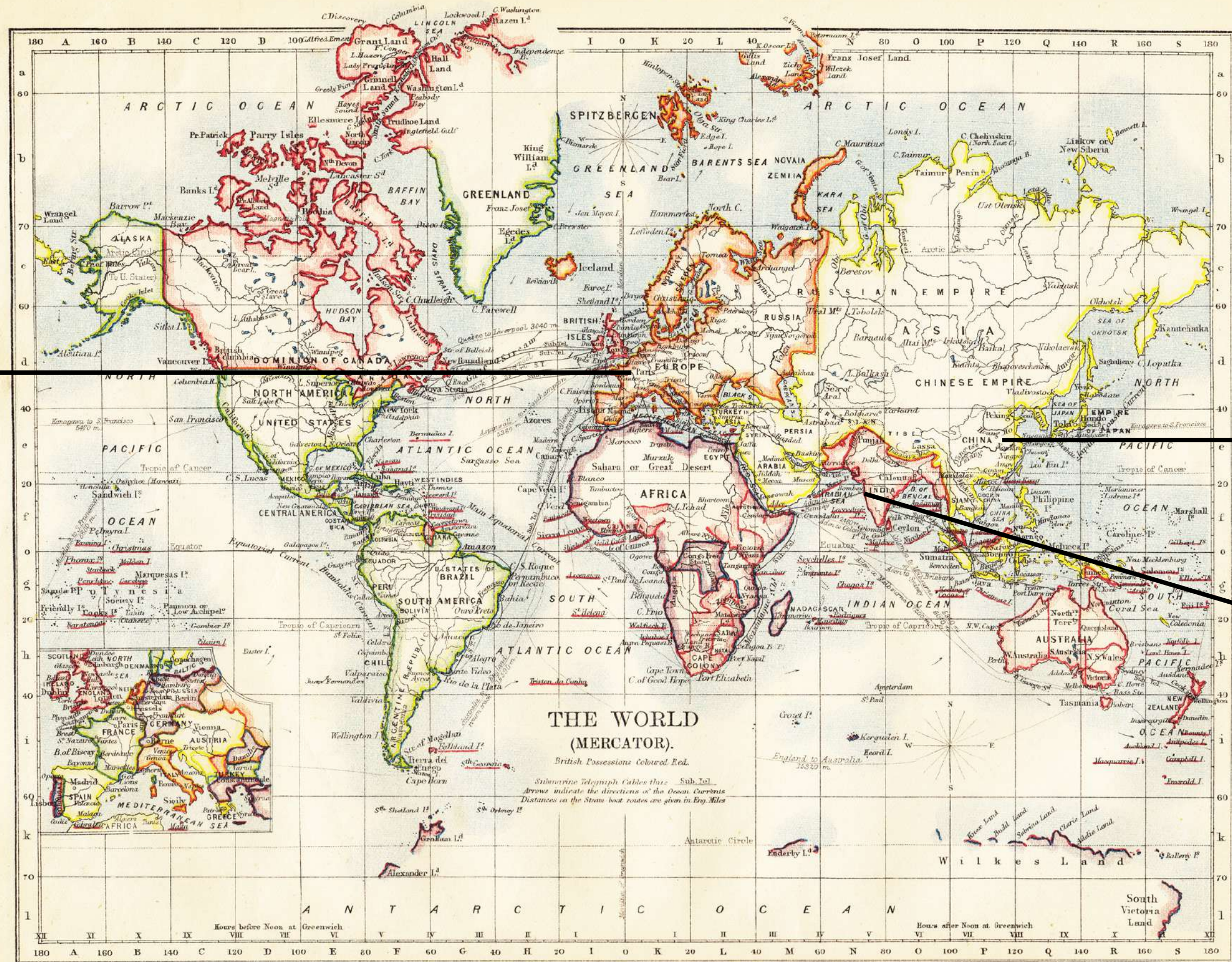


# Their EXPANSE

France

China

Bombay





# Their HISTORY

One of the smallest communities in the world with an outsized influence in shaping Modern India

7th Century CE- Left Persia and settled in present-day Gujarat in 8th century CE

18th Century- Entered the textile, tax farming, and liquor distillation industries

20th Century- Expansion of Tata group and beginning of Air India

- Expansion of Godrej

17th Century- Engaged in shipbuilding & built the Bombay dockyard.

19th Century-Key players in opium & cotton trade. J.N. Tata dreamt of a state-of-the-art steel plant





# The CHETTIARS





# Their EXPANSE



**South East Asia**  
(Singapore, Malaysia, Burma etc)

## ► Sri Lanka



# Their HISTORY

**Chettiar migration was male-dominated, semi-permanent and remittance-based.**

**17th Century- Salt traders in South India**

**20th Century- Rise in wealth due to tea, rice and rubber fields in Sri Lanka, Burma etc**

**Decline- Great Depression & nationalist outpourings against them in Burma, Japan etc**

**18th Century- Traders of pearls, arrack, cloth and rice in places like Sri Lanka and Calcutta.**

- Established first banking firm

**1930s- Possessed 1650 firms in Burma, 1000 each in Malaysia and Singapore, 500 in Sri Lanka and more.....**



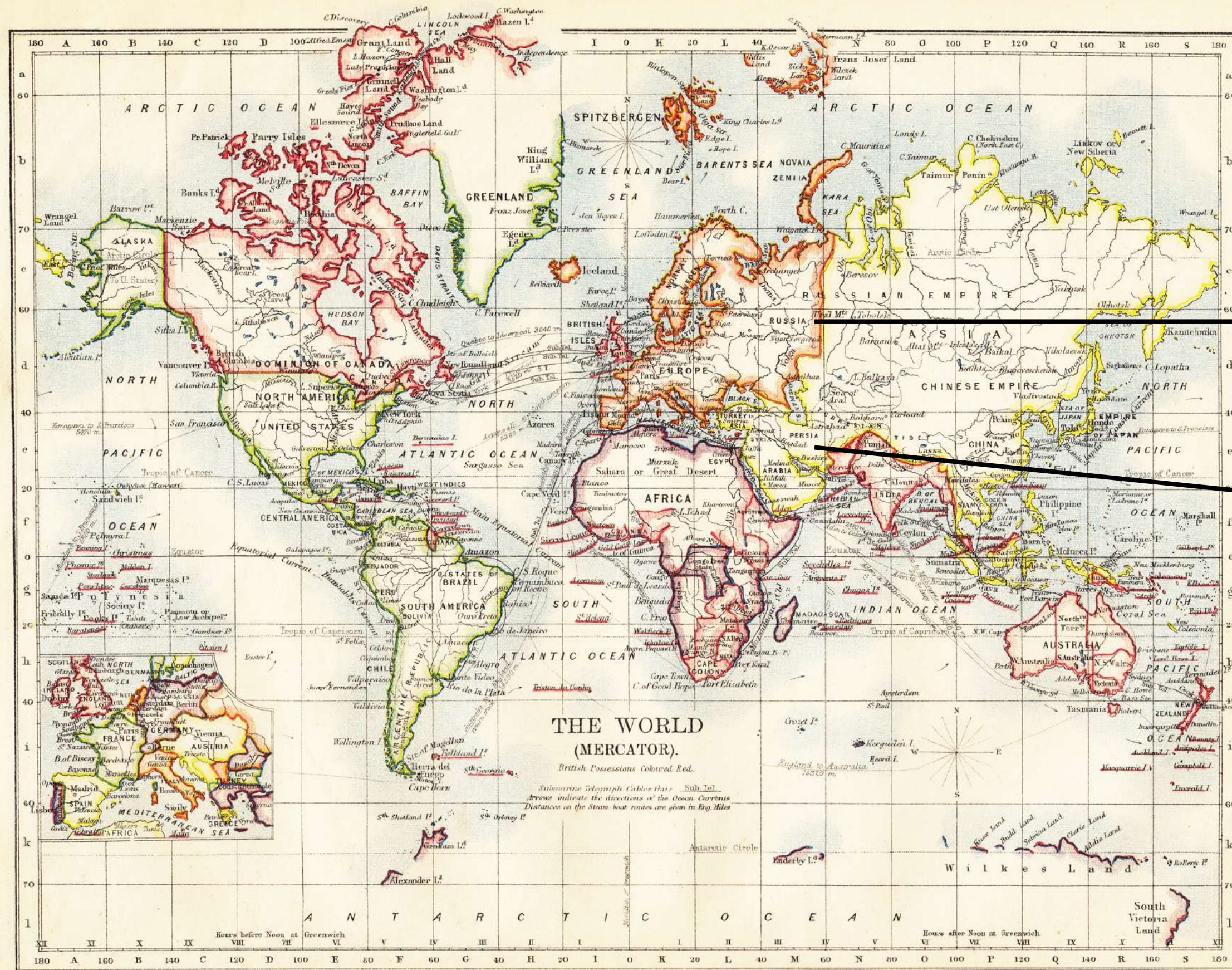


# *The* PUNJABIS





# Their EXPANSE



Russia

Pakistan, Iran & Afghanistan



# *Their* HISTORY

**Characterized by the migration of the Khatri Community.  
It was male-dominated and semi-permanent in nature.**

**01**

**Khatri merchant network was instrumental to the spread of Sikhism in Punjab.**

**02**

**Traders of textiles, spices and horses between India and central Asia. Acted as important moneylenders.**

**03**

**Post partition in 1947, refugees to the Indian side of Punjab played an important role in establishing manufacturing clusters in Punjab, especially the bicycle industry.**



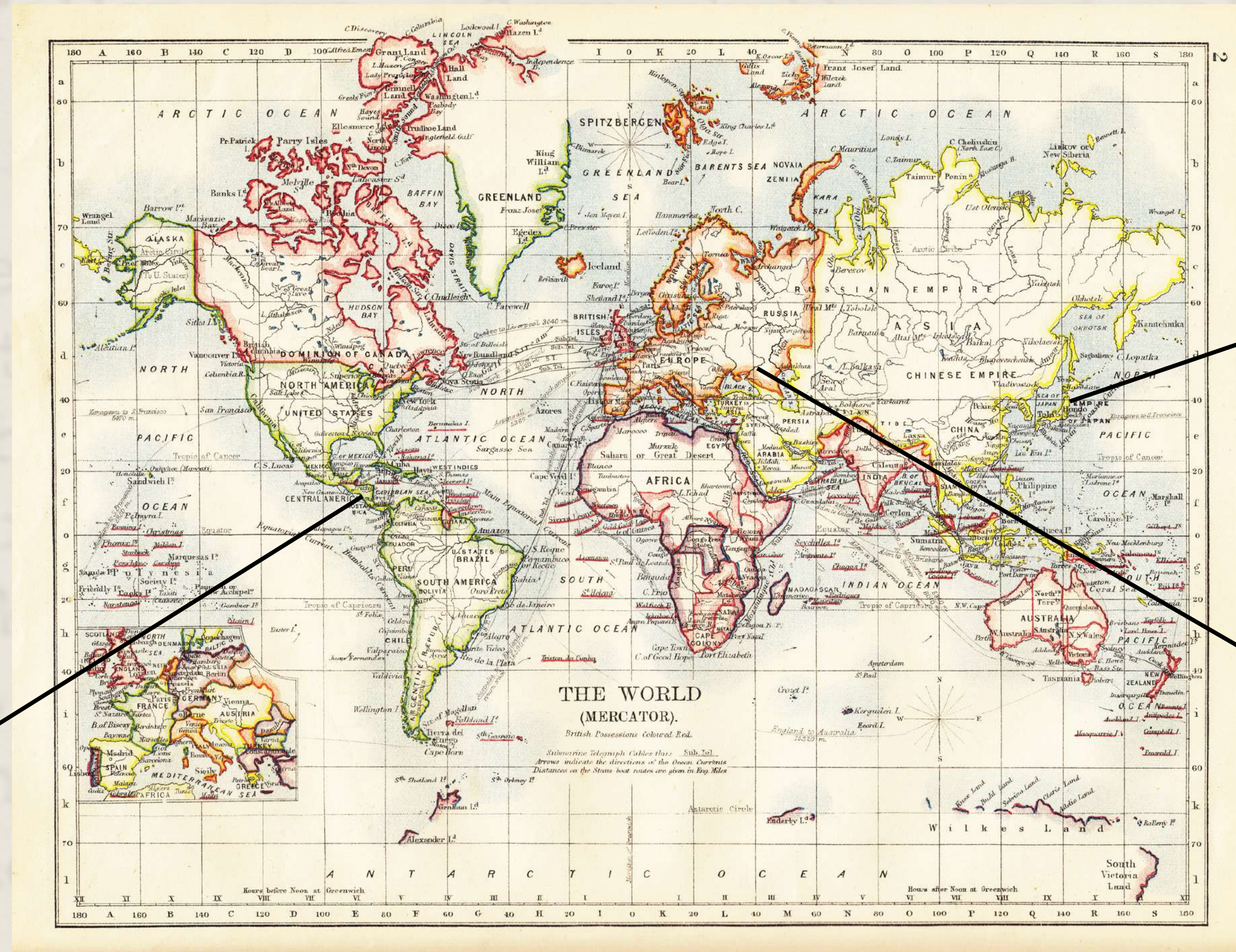


# The SINDHIS





# Their EXPANSE



Panama

Japan

Uzbekistan



# Their HISTORY

01

Sindhis usually refer to Hindus who migrated from Sindh either before or after Partition.

02

Penchant for Electronics - Chicago Radio, the loudspeakers on which the Indian freedom movement was relayed to the masses, was the brainchild of Nanik Motwane, a Sindhi migrant.

03

Karachi Bakery- post-Partition migrant Sindhi entrepreneur, Khanchand Ramnani, who started the Karachi Bakery in Hyderabad in 1953. It has become synonymous with the city of Hyderabad itself.





# The MARWARIS





# Their HISTORY

**Marwari migration was mostly within India, arguably because Rajasthan was not a coastal region with historic international trading connections**

**01**

**Major communities- Aggarwals, Maheshwaris and Oswals**

**02**

**Dominated the field of finance & commerce.  
Engaged in the cotton, cloth & opium trade along with moneylending & brokering.  
Widespread presence in Calcutta.**

**03**

**In the early 20th century, their engagement in the public sphere grew through charity, philanthropy and the freedom movement.**



**Key feature: Their migration has been closely linked with state patronage, a flair for spotting opportunities in new regions and also moving out early from regions with declining opportunities**



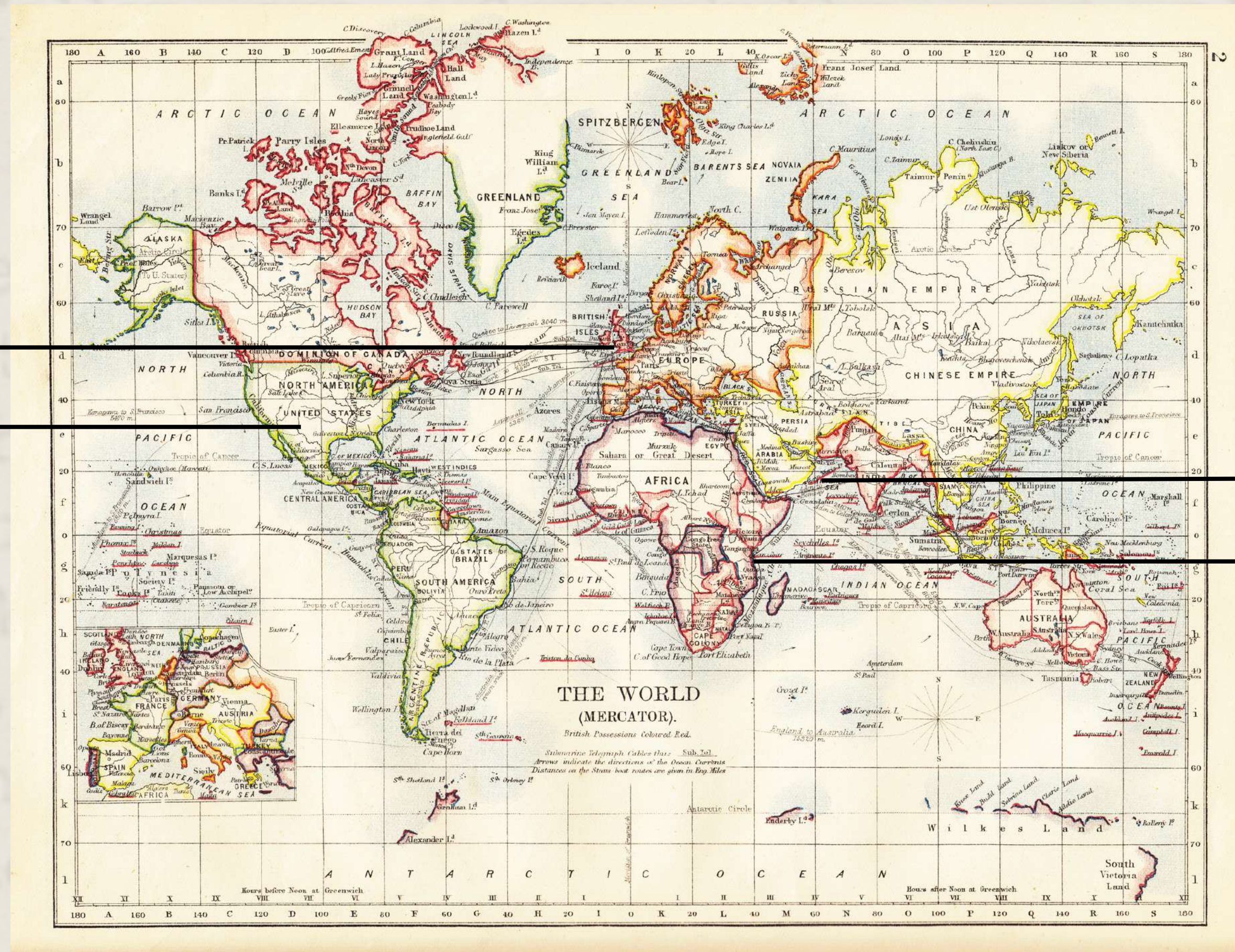
# The GUJARATIS





# Their EXPANSE

UK  
USA



Muscat

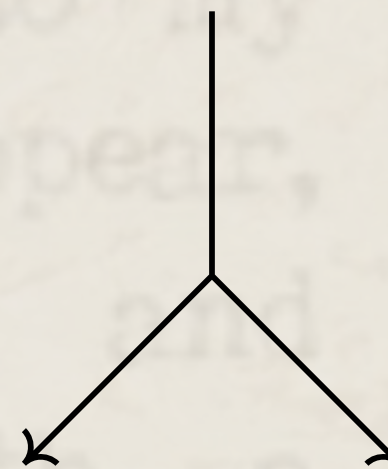
Zanzibar



# Their HISTORY



Characterized by the migration of two main communities-  
**Kachchhi mercantile migration in the 19th century & Patidar migration in the 20th century**



## **Kachch Mercantile Migration**

- They hosted a vibrant culture of trade, banking, insurance and shipbuilding
- Their fleet comprised over 400 ocean-going ships
- Also traded dates, pearls and ivory in the 19th century with counterparties as far away as the USA

## **Patidar/Patel Mercantile Migration**

- Associated with retail and wholesale trade, but they also came to dominate the ginning industry in Uganda
- Scored big in motels in the USA. From just two motels in the 1950s, the Patels comprised over half of all the moteliers in the US by the end of the 20th century





# *The* **MUSLIM MERCHANTS**





# Their HISTORY

**Characterized by migration of three communities in India- Sunni Memons, Shi'ite Khojas and Bohras**

**01**

**Memons- Shared a large claim in rice industry in the 19th century**

**02**

**Khojas- Prominent business family, Currimbhoys were engaged in shipping and opium trade.**

- **Rose to become the largest indigenous group after the Tatas for a short while.**

**03**

**Bohras- Prominent shipping merchants in the 17th century**





# *The* CHRISTIANS & JEWS





# *Their* HISTORY

**01**

## European Christians

- East India Company acquired taxation revenue rights in the 19th century.
- Scottish enterprises dominated British business in India by the end of the 19th century.
- Major outlets established by foreign migrants- Spencer's in Madras, Larsen & Toubro by Danish migrants, Monginis by Italian migrants etc

**02**

## Baghdadi Jews

- Sassoon family prominently contributed to Jewish migration.
- They owned dockyards, oil mills, cotton mills etc in India.
- They were the major promoter of the Bank of India, founded in 1906.
- Many Jews migrated to India for an English education and protected status before migrating to other places.





# Migration of CAPITAL

Stayed within family and managed by sons, nephews etc

Migrations were directed to places with low share of trading castes

Bankers & Diamond merchants expanded Indian investment overseas in 1960s-80s

People diverted to management education as a way of becoming rich

Most merchants paid back to their community through social and religious charity

20th Century- Evolved to transnational business

Social base of entrepreneurship widened with latecomers joining



